

Human Thought

Its Forms and Its Tasks

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translated from *Den menneskelige Tanke* (1910)

København og Kristiania:

Gyldendalske Boghandel, Nordisk Forlag, 1910

Contents

Foreword	5
I. The Psychology of Thought (Functions)	7
A. Psychic Energy	7
B. Intuition, Association, and Comparison	21
a. Sensation	21
b. Recognition	21
c. Memory- and Imagination-Intuition	21
d. Association of Ideas	21
e. Comparison	21
C. Judging	21
a. The Formation of Judgment	21
b. Obstacles to the Formation of Judgment	21
c. Subject and Predicate	21
d. The Validity of Judgment	21
II. The History of Thought	23
A. Animism, Platonism, and Positivism	23
B. Ancient and Modern Thinking	23
III. The Forms of Thought (The Categories)	26
A. The History and Method of the Doctrine of Categories	26
B. Fundamental Categories	26
C. Formal Categories	26
a. Identity	26
b. Quality-Relations	26
c. Negation	26
d. Rationality	26

D. Real Categories	26
a. Causality	26
b. Totality	26
c. Development	26
E. Ideal Categories	26
1) Formal Differences	26
2) Real Differences	26
IV. The Tasks of Thought (Problems)	28
Introduction	28
A. Cognition	28
a. Forms and Principles	28
b. Forms and Objects	28
B. World-View	28
a. Science and World-View	28
b. Unity and Multiplicity	28
c. Spirit and Matter	28
d. Subsistence and Development	28
C. Valuation	28
a. The Ethical Problem	28
b. The Religious Problem	28

Foreword

The life of thought, which it is the task of my book to describe, is intimately interwoven with the other sides of the life of the spirit. I have sought to show that thought cannot serve the life of the spirit as a whole unless it first and foremost becomes master in its own domain and unfolds itself according to its own laws as an independent side of the life of the spirit. That this unfolding, when it is rightly carried through, will bring with it great and far-reaching changes in personal life as a whole, is something of which I become more and more convinced. There are here oppositions and problems that will take on ever sharper forms, and I feel no admiration for those who here sense no sting, although they have sufficient opportunity to come to know the life of thought.

Just as I have on the whole stressed the personal factor in all thinking, the more this approaches the border-regions, so too I have not concealed that my own stance at thought's final station has a personal character, and I have not been able to refrain from stating how, in my experience, one feels at this station.

I still have much to learn. My work will need filling out and correction on many points. But beyond the framework I have given here, I cannot go. And it affords me a good place to work. May there be one or another who could also find work here, even if this work should lead him to alter both the framework and its content.

August 1910.

Harald Høffding.

I. The Psychology of Thought (Functions)

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A. Psychic Energy

1. The task I have set myself in this book is to investigate human thought—a task that all philosophers have set themselves, whether they have been conscious of it or not. For all questions that can be raised concerning life and existence depend—both with respect to the way in which they are posed and with respect to the way in which they are answered—on the conception one has of the nature and operation of thought. It is therefore also an outline of my philosophy that I shall give here. That is to say: I shall give an account of the thoughts to which I have come back again and again, when I have occupied myself with such questions as: the presuppositions of science, the significance of the results of science for one's view of life, and the relation between scientific cognition and other sides of the human life of the spirit.

2. We know thought best as reflection. The word *Eftertanke*—"after-thought"—I use not only in its strict sense, "in one's thinking to *seek after* something or *pursue* something," but also in the sense that thought *comes after* an immediate experience. Reflection thus presupposes that we have seen, felt, experienced something. During the experience we were perhaps wholly absorbed in it; but now we seek to bring it forth anew, either to dwell once more on what was experienced, or to go through its various parts or properties or its relations to other experiences. In mere dwelling, reflection is one with a beholding, a mere representing. But such dwelling can scarcely persist for long in a wholly quiescent form. Involuntarily—perhaps precisely because of the interest that what is experienced holds—a movement of thought will be released, one that serves to bring out its inner and outer relations. Thus when the poet involuntarily reaches for similes and images in order really to let his subject come to expression. Or when perhaps

it is precisely the contrast with other experiences that serves to illuminate the peculiar character of the single experience. Both likeness and difference can thus serve to cast a clearer light on what was given in the original experience, and reflection therefore does not necessarily stand in opposition to it, but can work in its service and in its spirit, when it has itself vanished.

By the word experience we think chiefly of states in which we were essentially receptive. But reflection can also serve the involuntary life of the spirit, where this appears as urge or striving. In an instinctive or inspired manner, involuntary striving is often led to its goal without any reflection being needed, and perhaps better than could happen with the help of any reflection. When reflection comes to operate in our action, it will be because the involuntary striving met resistance. There may then be needed a deliberation upon what it really is that is being striven for, upon this goal's relation to other possible or actual endeavors, and upon the ways and means that can lead to the goal. Here too it is through the bringing-out of likenesses and differences that reflection renders its service. And here too a difference can appear between dwelling and movement. It may be that the representation of the goal is held fast without great oscillations, and that the relation to ways and means or to other possibilities plays a subordinate role, as when the helmsman stares at the compass or the seamark, and his hand involuntarily moves the rudder according to what he sees. But it may also be that the strongest movement back and forth among various possibilities takes place and must take place before the decisive concentration that is called decision sets in.

The arising of reflection is like a kind of awakening, not from sleep or from unconsciousness, but from the involuntary mental life and its experiences, from states that may provisionally be characterized as sensation, intuiting, representing, mood, emotion, urge, and striving. In its dwelling form, reflection stands closest to the involuntary mental life. In its striving to bring out likenesses and differences, it moves further away from the involuntary. Linguistic usage marks this difference rather aptly by distinguishing between *thinking of* something and *thinking over* something. It is the latter kind of reflection, the discursive, mobile kind, that we shall have most use for in what follows, since it is the one we can best observe, and likewise the one that plays the decisive role in the tasks of thought. Only for this kind of reflection do problems exist. In what follows I therefore understand by thinking this kind of reflection. And yet there is only a difference of degree between the two kinds. Only for a brief moment is a dwelling representing, a holding-fast of a memory-image, possible; precise observation shows that in greater or smaller rhythms we move toward and away from the object we are thinking

of. And every return can bring with it a recognition, so that the relation of likeness comes to play a role just as in discursive reflection. Perhaps the representation was new to us at the first moment; but through repeated dwelling it becomes familiar. Apart from this too, dwelling reflection by no means excludes that manifold other representations and experiences can contribute and perhaps precisely condition the interest that makes continued holding-fast of a single representation possible. What holds for discursive reflection will therefore also hold, to a certain degree, for the dwelling kind.

It emerges from this description that the work of thought consists in comparison, in distinguishing or finding likenesses. When I think over something, I seek to determine its relation to something else, and the more relations of likeness and difference I find, the better I have thought it through. This holds of course also when it is one and the same object that I examine in different connections and under different conditions; I then compare the different ways in which the object appears in the different cases.

But comparison in turn presupposes a holding-together or combining, synthesis. I can compare two objects only when I either have them given to me simultaneously in my sensation, my memory, or my imagination, or else retain a representation of the one while the other is present to sensory observation. If the one object constantly vanished entirely when the other emerged, no comparison could take place. The work of thought consists in a combining by which likenesses and differences become determinative for the relations in which the objects are placed to one another in the connection that results from the work. Synthesis is an expression of energy, of the capacity to perform work.

The resistance that is overcome through this work is due to the objects against which reflection is directed and which are given in the involuntary mental life—in sense-sensation, memory or imagination, feelings of pleasure and displeasure, urge and striving.

The combining work must become the more difficult, the greater the multiplicity of objects that are to be brought into relation with one another. The fullness of content can be so great that the psychic energy available in the particular case cannot master it. There then threatens a dissolution of the mental life, a transition to chaos.

Yet it depends not only on the multiplicity, but also on the degree of difference that the objects present. The more they resemble one another, so that they can fuse, or so that at least the work done in the case of the one need not be repeated in the case of the other, the less work is required. Objects that stand in strong mutual opposition, or perhaps even conflict, require a great energy if they are all to be taken up into the conscious connection of the mental life. This holds both for the inquirer, who must find a point of

view from which the conflicting can stand as one, and for the practically striving person, who must subordinate the conflicting impulses and interests to the thought of a great and guiding purpose.

It will, thirdly, depend on how independent a place the individual objects are to occupy in the connection that is being worked on. A schematic whole is easier to form than a whole that lets the peculiarities of the individual objects each come into their own. Here it is precisely likeness that can create a difficulty, since it easily leads to fusion and thereby to the abolition of the independence of individual objects. On the other hand, from this point of view a pronounced difference or opposition can be a relief.

Furthermore, a greater work is required the further apart the objects lie from one another in time and space. The simultaneous and the near join together involuntarily, and the connection perhaps even forces itself upon us. And if we leave the objects before us in order to immerse ourselves in the world of memory and imagination, here too the connection can often form itself with ease; “with great ease thoughts take up their abode with one another,” but when it is a matter of holding together a present object with distant memories, or with ideals that have been properly to the fore in the soul only in isolated moments of enthusiasm, then special demands are made on psychic energy. To have, in the situation of the moment, the treasures of one’s experiences, one’s reflection, and one’s ideality fully at one’s disposal is perhaps the greatest testimony to mental energy.

Finally, it plays a role how close and intimate a connection the objects, despite their difference, are to enter into. There are here many degrees, from wholly external juxtaposition and grouping to the inner connection that a scientific concept, an artistically formed image, or a great decision can express.

Besides these five conditions—which might be said to form an analogy to what mass is in the case of physical energy—account must also be taken of the speed with which the synthesis proceeds. The genius and the man of will can in an instant expend a capital of energy that other people must distribute over a longer span of time. In the domain of the life of feeling, this opposition appears as an opposition between vehemence and inwardness, emotion and disposition¹, and analogous oppositions hold for the other sides of the mental life. In research, discovery often forms an analogy to emotion, the conduct of proof to disposition.

The psychic energy that expresses itself in synthesis we measure by taking all these circumstances into account. Of exact measurement there is of course no question here,

¹See on this my *Psychologi* IV, 7; VI E, 4–5.

only of an evaluative estimate. But as soon as we seek to give grounds for why one work of thought, one intellectual orientation, one view of life can be called lower or higher than another, we must take all these circumstances into account, and we in fact do so, more or less consciously, and more or less precisely. There is less psychic energy available in the dream-state, where the changing objects each release their own train of representations, than in the waking state, where dominant purposive thoughts bring about a main direction. It is a purely psychological measure that we apply here. And even though, in forming the concept of psychic energy, we have had guidance in the analogy with the concept of physical energy, that concept is nevertheless built upon its own peculiar experiences, in which physical or physiological observations and investigations need play no decisive role. For this reason we need not fail to appreciate the significance of the attempts that have been made, from the experimental-psychological and physiological side, to measure the brain-work presupposed in certain elementary mental activities—e.g. calculating or remembering—through its relation to the muscular work that can be performed simultaneously with it. One can detect such thought-work by the diminution it produces in the muscular work performed at the same time. But this very measurement presupposes that one can, by purely psychological means, distinguish between more difficult and easier mental work; otherwise one moves in a circle. The brain-work corresponding to the mental work described above is, after all, not known directly, but only through the very mental work to which it is assumed to correspond.

3. Reflection presupposes objects on which it can exercise its combining and comparing activity. But now these objects? Does the law of synthesis hold for them as well? We stand here before a question of a peculiar difficulty, closely bound up with the whole nature of the mental life. It is only reflection that acquaints us with the objects. It is the medium through which they are accessible to us. The involuntary mental life in its immediate unfolding must not be described and judged straightway according to the way in which it shows itself to reflection. It is a life within which we are not permitted to presuppose properties and determinations that first come into being through the work of reflection. When, in isolated moments, we are able to immerse ourselves in this involuntary—but not for that reason unconscious—life in such a way that we can afterwards retain a memory of it, it stands before us as a stream, a gliding-along of manifold objects, which we designate as sensations, memories, moods, endeavors, and so on. It is not a chaos of independent objects; already in the involuntary mental life there are connections and wholes as well as differences and oppositions. Every word we use about what we can retain from the involuntary states bears witness to this. Most

striking, no doubt, is the continuity; this is why the word “stream” offers itself so readily for what we call the immediately given. But it is not a uniform stream. Differences of quality make themselves felt; otherwise we could not distinguish between the kinds of objects called above sensations, memories, and so on. And there can be eddies in the stream, or windings, so that the direction is not kept in a straight line. That is to say, strivings of different tendency, of more or less opposite direction, can make themselves felt. With this is bound up, again, that inhibitions can set in, while in other cases, where the different tendencies go in the same direction, a facilitation or an acceleration can appear.

Through the indefinite and figurative expressions that alone stand at our disposal for indicating the basis of objects that reflection presupposes, it shines through that this basis forms no absolute opposition to what emerges as a consequence of the work of reflection. There too we find both unity and multiplicity, both continuity and discontinuity, and we find many degrees and nuances of these relations. It is therefore not justified, with the older English school (*Locke, Hume, Mill*), to conceive the immediately given in the mental life in an atomistic way, as if it consisted in a multiplicity of mutually independent elements. Both in the psychic and in the physical domain, it is only reflection that leads to the formation of atomic concepts, guided by the urge to make the differences as distinct as possible, so that the connection of them can become as clear and perspicuous as possible. The unity to which reflection bears witness, and which it itself seeks to bring about, thereby becomes enigmatic. But it is also unjustified, as in our day especially *William James*² and *Henri Bergson*³ have attempted, to present that involuntary life as standing in the sharpest opposition to reflection and its work. It then becomes, in the last analysis, the indescribable and inconceivable, and it would become an insoluble enigma how there can be any knowledge at all of that “immediately given” from which reflection is nonetheless constantly to draw. James and Bergson represent a significant reaction against intellectualism’s misunderstanding and overvaluation of the significance of reflection, a reaction that in several respects recalls the stand taken by *Hamann, Herder*, and *Jacobi* against *Kant*. Not pure reason, but the immediate stream of the life of the spirit is, they maintain, the highest, and brings truth forth. The distinctions and definitions of thought are necessary in order that we may practically find our way in life. And analyzing science has carried the opposition to the immediately given still further—an

² *The Stream of Thought*. Mind 1884 (reprinted as Chap. 9 of *Principles of Psychology*). Later especially *A pluralistic universe* (1909), Sect. 7.

³ *Les données immédiates de la conscience* (1888). Later especially in *Introduction à la Métaphysique*. (*Revue de Métaphysique et de Morale* 1903).

opposition that language itself already favors, by forming independent words for the individual objects and by taking spatial relations as the basis for our intuitive images. It is as though a Fall had taken place when reflection awoke and turned, inquiringly, toward the involuntary life from which it had itself sprung.

Without a kinship between the involuntary mental life and reflection, it would be impossible to understand how the latter could arise. But in the very descriptions that James and Bergson give of what, for them, in sharp opposition to all elaboration by thought, is the immediately given—descriptions that are masterpieces of descriptive psychology—it is nonetheless expressly stated that in this “given” there are differences and connections, qualities and continuities. James emphasizes especially the constant transitions (continuous transitions) and the difficulty of distinguishing between relation and term (relation and matter related); Bergson stresses especially the undivided and yet heterogeneous nature of the inner stream (*durée hétérogène et indistincte; durée dont les moments se pénètrent*). But with this an inner possibility for the arising of reflection has been indicated. The whole weight must not be placed on the external causes (practical need, the mechanics of language, and the technique of science). The motive for the awakening of reflection is given with the opposition between continuity and qualitative multiplicity, between the connection and the individual elements. Herein lies the possibility of an inhibition of the involuntary stream, an inhibition that only discursive reflection can remedy, through the clarity and definiteness it is able to bring. As a combining that is accomplished through comparison, reflection can bring about clarity concerning the relation between continuity and discontinuity, unity and multiplicity. And it is not anything wholly foreign that it brings in by its work; for already in the immediately given there appear, after all, likenesses and differences, connection and multiplicity—and likewise, what is especially significant, an involuntary striving to bring about harmony among the different tendencies. If there were not such an original striving, it would be unjustified to speak of a stream, of a *continuité mouvante*, a *unité de direction*⁴! There shows itself here, then, an analogy to what, in the case of reflection, we called synthesis—a tendency to gather and unite. And reflection awakens when there is a special urge for a fuller carrying-through of this tendency than is possible within the involuntary mental life. Already within this—not only after reflection has

⁴One of my young listeners wrote to me some years ago: “I can declare myself free of every purpose, as of every interest or belief in anything outside or inside me. I do indeed feel something willing, something pressing forward, but it lives, as it were, its own life, pushes aside everything that gets in its way, and surely never commits any act that is not to its own advantage.”—Here reflection has brought no result, only dissolution; but the involuntary life has maintained itself in its unity and in its definite direction, which was all the more striking to the young psychologist the less his reflection could attain to any firm standpoint.

awakened—crises and catastrophes can arise, and chaos can threaten. A work can be required even before reflection can awaken; but the difficulties arise, are worked on, and are resolved on different terms in the involuntary mental life than where reflection has taken the helm. Perhaps some of the most significant things in our mental life take place in the regions below the domain of reflection, and it is often only the after-effects of these deep-lying processes that reflection has to deal with. It will always be impossible to demonstrate that at any point we stand before an immediately given in the absolute sense, that is, one in which absolutely no psychic work has been done. What we in each particular case call immediately given deserves this name only in relation to a certain definite psychic work, while in comparison with other objects it would perhaps have to be regarded as the result of a work.

4. By starting from reflection and seeking to become clear about its way of operating, we arrived at the concept of synthesis, and we then found that this concept could also be applied to the involuntary mental life, which forms the constant basis from which reflection springs, in order thereupon to make that basis itself an object of its activity. We must make ourselves familiar with the fact that the involuntary mental life, as it unfolds prior to the awakening of reflection, can be illuminated and designated only by way of analogy. We apprehend it only in analogy with clear reflection, and the expressions of language are throughout drawn from the world of reflection. So far is that involuntary mental life from being the thing easiest to apprehend, that it takes precisely great art to get a proper view of it in its difference from the mental life shaped by reflection. What one calls sound common sense operates, in its psychology, with concepts drawn from the world of reflection. A childlike tendency makes itself felt to regard everything in the mental life as the fruit of clearly conscious thinking, of deliberation and calculation. One personifies, so to speak, not only outer but also inner nature, placing a person behind the person. The childlike psychology explains personal life itself, in its involuntary unfolding, by supposing that behind it there is a person who consciously thinks whatever stirs in it—just as in older works on optics one can find depicted a man inside the head, looking at the image that the light-rays form on the retina!

Reflection is required in order to discover and apprehend the involuntary mental life, and yet the peculiarity of the latter consists in the fact that reflection plays no role in it. This difficulty can be resolved only by our apprehending and expressing the involuntary—insofar as any memory of it persists after the awakening of reflection—in analogy with what we know clearly from the world of reflection itself. This is what we do when we say that synthesis is the fundamental form, not only for comparing

reflection, but also for the involuntary mental life, and is thus the most comprehensive psychological concept.—

But now a new difficulty arises. Synthesis means combining—but there must then be something that is combined, and this something must be a multiplicity. The objects toward which reflection directs itself in order to hold them together and compare them form a coherent multiplicity; each individual object comes into being for us through an act of distinguishing. And in a single object we can again distinguish individual sides, properties, or parts, which we may call elements. The result seems then to be that we end in an opposition between synthesis and elements, and that the multiplicity of elements is the constant presupposition for synthesis being able to operate! From this one might then draw the conclusion that what is original in the mental life was a multiplicity of elements, and that only at a later point of development did the combining activity intervene. This conception was also asserted in its day by John Locke, and it still often haunts psychology. It relies on the analogy with the formation of a mechanical whole out of elements that could be pointed out beforehand each by itself, as when a heap of sand is formed from grains of sand that previously lay each in its own place and are only now brought together. The question becomes whether this analogy is justified.

When reflection awakens, the mental life does not, however, begin with it; for then it would have no objects. The elements—that is, the parts, sides, or properties that reflection can distinguish in the object or objects, and that it can determine through their mutual likenesses and differences—are, after all, precisely the fruit of a work of thought. They are drawn out of the connection in which they involuntarily occurred, and set in a certain opposition to one another—an opposition without which they could not become objects of clear consciousness. And the characterization that each individual element, and thereby each individual object, receives is conditioned by its relation to other elements or objects. At no point is it justified to assume isolated elements in the mental life, each absolutely independent by itself—a kind of absolute psychic atoms. That is to confuse the effect of reflection with reflection's own basis—at bottom, again an example of the naive psychology that tends, after all, to confuse differences that thought first makes with originally given differences.

And insofar as we succeed in retaining a memory of the state we are in when involuntariness prevails, this state appears—and here the masters of descriptive psychology are undoubtedly right—not as a chaos of independent parts, but as a stream, a pulsation, yet not without differences, but such that there is a connection even between the lowest troughs and the highest crests of the waves. We find, as far as can be judged, unity and

multiplicity so interwoven with each other that they cannot be separated in an external manner. It was, after all, precisely in the urge to gain greater clarity about their relation that we found the possibility and the motive for the awakening of reflection.

At no element can we, in the domain of the mental life (any more than in that of matter), come to a stop as absolutely isolated or absolutely simple. There constantly poses itself, for reflection, the task of finding a connection between the elements or objects that might seem to be isolated, and of finding an inner multiplicity in the elements or objects that appear as simple. It is a sign of the dullness of reflection when it comes to a stop too early in either of these respects. In other words: the law of synthesis must always be carried through anew with respect to the objects or elements themselves.

On the other hand, neither can there be any absolutely conclusive synthesis. As long as the mental life lasts, new objects are taken up into the involuntary stream and are involuntarily worked into it. They are new drops, or perhaps new brooks, which are partly reshaped by the stream and partly can also gain influence on its character and its course. To this is added the character of the new riverbeds that the stream must form for itself when the terrain changes. And as long as reflection is awake, it will constantly be able to set itself the task of bringing about a greater, more comprehensive, and more intimate synthesis than before. There is always a psychic work to be done. The synthesis that has hitherto enclosed the multiplicity of the mental life can again come to stand as object or element for a later synthesis. As soon as we become conscious of our preceding mental states and activities, such a transition to a new synthesis takes place, whether or not this signifies a progress, a more valuable state. It is a new I that becomes conscious of our earlier I's. No synthesis is definitive. Even the philosophy that spoke most of higher unity always fell into embarrassment when it had to speak of the highest unity.

It can of course be entirely justified, in a special connection, with a view to a particular investigation, to disregard these difficulties of principle and to regard elements or objects as if they were absolute and simple. Every special scientific investigation presupposes a certain abstraction. If, e.g., experimental psychology really needs to operate with a kind of psychic atoms or flashes as independent and simple, this can be just as justified as when, in natural science, one operates with material atoms. But one must avoid the dogmatism that confuses concepts we have arranged for the needs of an investigation with ultimate realities. And likewise it can be justified that in everyday speech, or in a practical—e.g. ethical or juridical—respect, we regard the individual as an absolute unity with a completed synthesis, without regard to the fact that synthesis at bottom signifies a work, an activity, not something given once and for all. There is an irrational

relation between the mental life and what we call its elements. The point now is to find as many elements as possible; but it can be justified and necessary to confine oneself to a few decimal places, provided only that one does not forget that the question is then not exhausted. The irrational is here, as everywhere, both a barrier and a task.

There expresses itself here an antinomy that is closely bound up with the essence of the mental life and is peculiar to the concept of personality. Mental life and personality cannot be conceived as products of previously given elements, since the elements we know always have their properties precisely by being members of the mental life. We here come to move in a circle, unless we are clear that an inexhaustible reciprocal action prevails: the parts are determined by the whole, and the whole by the parts. In each particular case, in each particular psychological consideration, we must investigate how far the synthesis, the formation of the whole, has advanced, and on this basis observe how the emergence of a new object operates. But the very distinction between synthesis and object is always more or less artificial in relation to the constant interplay of meeting and parting, of continuity and discontinuity, of wholeness and dissolution. There is here a mental rhythmicity that forms an analogy to—or rather a prototype for—the rhythms that characterize the course of organic life, a rhythmicity that by no means begins with reflection, but, by all we can judge, already makes itself felt in the involuntary mental life. Indeed, this rhythmicity recurs in the very relation between reflection and the involuntary course of the mental life. The difficulty of understanding the origin of the mental life rests precisely on the fact that it cannot be explained as a product of previously given elements, but from its very first moment moves in a rhythm—and that in a rhythm of the peculiar kind that none of the members in the rhythm can have absolute priority over the other.

5. In the history of the concept of synthesis this antinomy has been a stumbling-block. The concept of synthesis itself is an old idea, traceable in Plato and Aristotle, and especially in Plotinus in antiquity, and which from Leibniz's time on has always, with more or less energy, been asserted in psychology and in philosophy generally⁵.

Hume cut the knot by dissolving the mental life into absolutely independent elements, and consistently he therefore found an insoluble enigma in all unity and connection in consciousness. The principle of unity (the uniting principle) was for him the unintelligible. *Kant* started from the opposite point of view, that it is precisely the unconnected, the

⁵On the history of the concept of synthesis in more recent times, see *Georges Dwelshauvers: La synthèse mentale* (Paris 1908), pp. 179–223 (an account of the concept of synthesis in Leibniz, Kant, Wundt, Høffding, and Pierre Janet).—In *S. Kierkegaard* this concept appears in an energetic and profound manner, especially in the measure he applies in his doctrine of the stages. See my book *Danske Filosofer*, pp. 153 f.; p. 165 f.

isolated and mutually independent, that is unintelligible to us, both in psychology and wherever else we meet it. But he still held fast to Locke's presupposition that, as the basis for thought's combining and ordering activity, there was given a multiplicity that was only now to be connected. Thereby he arrived at his fateful distinction between the form of cognition and its matter. This too was to cut the knot. And yet Kant did not lack the insight that already in the involuntary mental life there operate forms analogous to those that clear reflection employs. Synthesis is, he says, the effect of a blind but indispensable function of the soul, without which we would have no cognition at all, but of which we only rarely become conscious. It is the task of thought to form the synthesis into a concept. And this same blind function of the soul (Kant calls it imagination) is likewise what conditions the connection between the two extremes of our cognition, "sensation" and "understanding." It was surely only Kant's reluctance to give psychological considerations too large a place in his investigation that held him back from giving a fuller characterization of the involuntary course of the mental life. J. F. Fries developed Kant's doctrine further from this side and is even regarded by his disciples as the real discoverer of the involuntary basis⁶. But he then believed that in this basis—the spontaneous striving, the immediate cognition—he possessed a rule of truth exalted above all error. Unfortunately this rule is ineffable, since it can come to consciousness only in an imperfect and fragmentary way through reflection! A dogmatism comes to the fore in the firm belief in the validity of the involuntary mental life—a dogmatism that signifies a decided step backward in relation to Kant. Already when Fries assumes that "spontaneity" is not only continuous but also constant, he says more than any reflection could demonstrate. The irrational relation between immediacy and reflection is not strictly maintained.

This relation is, as already mentioned, very sharply emphasized by *Henri Bergson*. This thinker is not satisfied with the concept of synthesis, because it always presupposes an opposition between unity and multiplicity. Is it not an opposition—he asks—that recurs, whatever one thinks of or speaks about? What matters is to say *which* kind of unity and *which* kind of multiplicity we have in the mental life. The streaming life of the personality cannot be defined by means of concepts that always stand in a certain relation of opposition to one another. One cannot, through thesis and antithesis, arrive at a real unity. One must, conversely, immerse oneself in the immediate stream of the mental life in order to see the opposition emerge from it. Immediate beholding (intuition)

⁶Against this, see my review in *Göttinger Gelehrte Anzeiger* (1907) of "Abhandlungen der Frieseschen Schule. Neue Folge."

must take the place of reflection⁷.

Bergson's standpoint recalls, viewed from one side, that of Fries, except that he gives us, with far greater mastery, an understanding of what is meant by "spontaneity." But whereas Fries and his disciples held that true cognition is attained by translating, as well as we can, that spontaneous basis into the forms of reflection, Bergson demands that we subdue reflection and, by an act of will, dive down again into the immediate, feeling ourselves one with it. It stands here as an enigma how the validity of a cognition can be demonstrated without reflection. One of the special problems of thought will later give us occasion to bring out this difficult point in the philosophy of the brilliant French thinker.

In response to the remark that the concepts we use in our reflection to characterize the mental life—synthesis, unity, multiplicity, and the like—find application to all objects, I will maintain that the reason why that group of concepts constantly finds, and must find, application to all objects is to be sought precisely in the fact that they express the forms in which the mental life, and cognition in particular, unfolds itself. Only through the application of these forms does the appropriation, the taking-up into the connection of our own being, in which all understanding, all cognition consists, become possible. No wonder that all products of cognition bear their stamp! Our cognition consists in a conscious or unconscious analogy with our own being.—

The relation of opposition that has been discussed in the foregoing under various expressions (object and reflection, matter and form, spontaneity and reflection, intuition and analysis), *Stumpf* designates as a relation of opposition between phenomena and psychic functions⁸. With respect to this relation he advances, with all possible reservation, the hypothesis that psychic phenomena are not altered because they are analyzed. When we become aware of something in an observation that we did not notice at the first moment, this is supposed to bring about no change in our observation itself, but only in the degree of explicit consciousness we apply to it. A sound rings the same whether or not I notice individual tones in it; a dish makes the same impression whether I can distinguish something sour or sweet in its taste, or whether the taste acts as a unified whole. In my judgment it is, from the outset, not probable that this is how matters stand. The differentiated and differentiating attention in which analysis consists must alter the object for us. The fact that we have discovered a spot in an otherwise beautiful picture—a spot we did not notice at the first moment—can give the whole picture a

⁷*Introduction à la Métaphysique*. (Revue de Métaphysique et de Morale 1903, pp. 15–17.)

⁸*Erscheinungen und psychische Funktionen*. (Abhdl. der preussischen Gesellschaft der Wiss. 1907), pp. 15–21.

different character. The timbre changes; an element has, quite simply, been added that was not present in the first glance. And the relation between the individual parts is in each case a different one after the analysis than before. It can cost an exertion of will to return to the immediate beholding in which the particulars have not yet become the object of special apprehension. There is here a difference between experience and reflection that can scarcely be effaced. There are of course many degrees, as we shall come to see in what follows, in the investigation of the relation between intuiting and judging. And individual differences certainly also make themselves felt. In elastic natures the transition from experience to reflection, and vice versa, will take place relatively easily; and yet I should think that even in them a certain contrast-effect will make itself felt between the two states.

Stumpf, for that matter, will only maintain the possibility of a differentiated subsistence, during the experience, of what is first differentiated with consciousness during reflection. And he concedes that there is probably no absolute independence in the relation between phenomenon and function “under the usual, complicated circumstances of the psychic process.” Whether experimental investigations can, as he surmises, lead to any result here is doubtful. It is not easy to see how the difference between immediate experience and reflection could fall away. And in a psychological experiment it is difficult to obtain a wholly immediate experience.

Chemists often say that the atoms of the elements are present in compound substances—so that, e.g., carbon and oxygen are really present in carbonic acid. And *Stumpf* holds that the psychologist must have the same right in his domain. I think, however, that there is a difference. For the chemist can demonstrate that there are just as many parts by weight in carbonic acid as in carbon and oxygen each by itself; and at bottom that is all he means by that manner of speaking. Such an equivalence the psychologist is, for good reasons, debarred from demonstrating.—For that matter, a chemist such as *Sir William Ramsay* has expressly denied the right to take that manner of speaking literally, and *Ernst Mach* has expressed himself in the same direction. The analogy is therefore doubtful.—

We do not get beyond an antinomy between experience and reflection, and we may not, without further ado, transfer to the one what holds for the other. Experience itself we may think of neither as absolute continuity nor as a chaos of differences. The continuous and the discontinuous occur in it in all possible degrees, and it is only reflection that takes the opposition between continuity and discontinuity sharply into view, in that it—as will later be shown—receives the double task of finding differences where continuity was

immediately given, and intermediate links where discontinuity was immediately given.

B. Intuition, Association, and Comparison

a. Sensation

b. Recognition

c. Memory- and Imagination-Intuition

d. Association of Ideas

e. Comparison

C. Judging

a. The Formation of Judgment

b. Obstacles to the Formation of Judgment

c. Subject and Predicate

d. The Validity of Judgment

II. The History of Thought

A. Animism, Platonism, and Positivism

B. Ancient and Modern Thinking

III. The Forms of Thought (The Categories)

A. The History and Method of the Doctrine of Categories

B. Fundamental Categories

C. Formal Categories

a. Identity

b. Quality-Relations

1) Time

2) Number

3) Degree

4) Place

c. Negation

d. Rationality

D. Real Categories

a. Causality

b. Totality

c. Development

E. Ideal Categories

1) Formal Differences

2) Real Differences

IV. The Tasks of Thought (Problems)

Introduction

A. Cognition

a. Forms and Principles

b. Forms and Objects

α. Quality and Quantity

β. Succession and Causality

γ. Subject and Object

B. World-View

a. Science and World-View

b. Unity and Multiplicity

c. Spirit and Matter

d. Subsistence and Development

C. Valuation

a. The Ethical Problem

α. *Ethical Work.* (Formal Ethics)

β. *The Rationality of Ethical Valuation.* (Real Ethics)

b. The Religious Problem

α. *The Psychological Place of Religion*

β. *The Historical and the Philosophical Consideration*